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The Other Face of Obama

The Obama administration is likely to be more intrusive, and will work closely with China on security and co-operation in Asia—challenges that India can meet by imaginative diplomacy

In his historic Gettysburg address on June 1, 1865, amid a civil war to rid the US of slavery, former US President Abraham Lincoln proclaimed it as “a nation conceived in liberty and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal”. One century later, with racial discrimination still widely practised across the US, Martin Luther King, inspired by Mahatma Gandhi and driven by a belief in non-violent resistance, proclaimed in Washington in 1963, “I have a dream.” King’s dream was to end racial discrimination and secure justice and equal opportunities for Black (Afro) Americans. Former US President Lyndon Johnson’s programme for a “Great Society” in the 1960s, while stressing the elimination of poverty and racial injustice and focusing on education and healthcare, sought to transform King’s dream into reality. Barack Hussein Obama’s victory vividly demonstrates that King’s dream is becoming a reality.

Obama’s victory establishes that social justice is better achieved by providing equal opportunities than by reservations—a lesson India’s politicians will do well to take note of. Moreover, across the world, the American image of tempering power with compassion, which had taken a severe beating in the Bush years, will now be recast. Obama, who believes that Iraq “was a diversion from the terrorists who struck us on 9/11”, now says that priority will be given to Afghanistan. Asserting that “the greatest threat to the security of the Afghan and American people lies in the tribal regions of Pakistan, where terrorists train and strike into Afghanistan and move back”, Obama has said he would use “necessary assets, like satellites and predator drones”, to take out terrorist camps.

Unlike the Bush Administration, Obama has made it clear that he favours direct dialogue with Iran on its nuclear programme. He advocates moves towards a nuclear weapons-free world—a development India would welcome. At the same time, India would have to take note of Obama’s interest in the early conclusion of a Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT) and also a treaty

to end the production of fissile material for nuclear weapons. Though Obama came around to supporting the Indo-US nuclear deal, he earlier moved “killer amendments”, totally unacceptable to India. He appears to favour negotiations with the Russians to de-alert nuclear missiles and is keen on engaging China on a wide range of issues.

While Obama has made the right noises about Indian democracy, he has never visited India, though he has visited Pakistan in the 1980s. On October 31, Obama spoke of the need to support democracy in Pakistan and to increase non-military aid to that country. He added: “But we also have to help make the case that the biggest threat to Pakistan right now is not India, which has been its historical enemy, it is actually militants within its own borders. And if we can get them to refocus on that, then it is going to be critical to our success”. Eyebrows were, however, raised by a subsequent Obama assertion that the “US should try to resolve the Kashmir crisis”. No government in Delhi will agree to any such US role. Moreover, there is no dearth of Obama advisers determined to make civil nuclear cooperation with India difficult, particularly through restrictions on reprocessing of spent fuel. Obama also favours disincentives on outsourcing and advocates ending tax concessions on outsourcing. While the Bush Administration supported India’s moves to improve relations with all its neighbours, an Obama administration is likely to be more intrusive and work closely with China on major issues of security and co-operation in Asia.

These are challenges that can be met by imaginative diplomacy. Delhi also has leverage to influence US policies. Corporate America has substantial interest in many spheres, like sales of nuclear reactors and defence equipment like F-16 fighters to India. Such cooperation can obviously flourish only in the context of close political understanding. As consumer activist Ralph Nader noted recently, Obama is not unmindful of the clout of Corporate America, which will strongly oppose restrictions or disincentives on outsourcing. ■

